When the country was celebrating its 61st Republic Day, both of us flew into the enchanting state of the rising sun, Arunachal Pradesh. I was to take over as the governor on 27 January. We took off from Delhi in the morning and two hours later reached Guwahati, where we were received by a minister from Arunachal and our state's resident commissioner, besides some other officials from the state of Assam. From Guwahati, it was a six-hour journey by road or else a helicopter flight for an hour. We preferred to travel by the chopper to save time.

As we flew over the Brahmaputra valley, memories of my travels and stay in various places of the northeastern region flashed across my mind. During my army career, I had done three tenures and had served in three out of the seven northeastern states, namely Nagaland, Sikkim and Arunachal Pradesh. It needs to be stated that when the sun rises over India, its rays fall over the northeast at least an hour before they do on Delhi. I have always felt that there was a necessity of having an eastern standard time in India. Further, if one looks at the map and focuses on Guwahati or Shillong and draws an arc with a radius of 1000 kilometres, the circle would encompass eight countries. And it would include cities and towns like Kolkata, Dhaka, Kathmandu, Varanasi, Thimpu, Lhasa, Kunming, Mandalay, Chittagong and the border areas of Vietnam, Laos, and Thailand. Therefore this area assumes geo-strategic importance and is, in fact, the land link between India and Southeast Asia.

Historically, the Brahmaputra valley, surrounded by densely forested hills which rise northward to the Great Himalayas, is a land inhabited by an ancient civilization of plainsmen and tribals. It has a vibrant culture and was once a flourishing centre of trade. Assam tea has been exported to the UK since 1838. Oil was discovered in this area and a refinery was set up at Digboi in 1890. Even at the time of our independence in 1947, the northeastern region was amongst the most prosperous of the country. Abundant in oil, minerals, coal, forests and water, a large area is yet to be explored. It produces a huge quantity of tea and fruits like pineapples, oranges, leechies, apples and kiwis. Bamboo, cane, ginger, and other herbal and medicinal plants are aplenty. There is tremendous scope